the right place at the right time and made the right judgement call. The exact nature of his conversations with Captain Savitsky do not permit calibration of luck and judgement. Was Arkhipov the man who saved the world? His actions seem crucial to a sequence that resulted in the torpedo not being fired. So too, were those of Commander Morgan. What might have happened had they failed to stop Savitsky is explored further below.

'That deep mud in Cuba'

On the morning of Sunday, 28 October, as Khrushchev was telling the Presidium it was time to retreat, the United States was preparing for war. The Joint Chiefs expected to launch their attack on Cuba by Tuesday, 30 October. In the words of the army chief of staff, General Earle Wheeler: 'I never thought I'd live to see the day when I would want to go to war.'[51] Robert Kennedy had told Ambassador Dobrynin that, if necessary, the United States would remove the Soviet missiles by bombing them and that the President wanted a response to his proposal to end the crisis within twenty-four hours.

What would JFK have done if Khrushchev had not retreated when he did? On the answer to this question hangs a great deal about how we assess the risk of nuclear war, and about what lessons we think we can draw. There remains disagreement among the President's former advisors about what he would have done in these circumstances. Taylor, Nitze, and Dillon believed there would have been an invasion – Sorensen, Bundy and McNamara doubted an attack would have come then. They believed the President would have instead strengthened the blockade by including petroleum, oil and lubricants (POL).[52] David Ormsby-Gore was certainly not a hawk (and had extensive contact with the President during the crisis). He told the Foreign Office in November that the US was preparing to attack on Monday, 29 October, though he felt that they would have waited until the Tuesday.[53]

In 1987 Dean Rusk revealed what became known as 'the Cordier ploy.' Rusk said that JFK instructed him to lay the foundation for a public trade involving the Turkish missiles. Andrew Cordier was a former UN Under-